

indicates the use of balsam, which is “indigenous in various parts of Arabia,” as an ingredient in the “Myrabolan comfit.”²⁵ Such references emphasize Arabia’s exoticism and refined taste, as well as the sweetness and fragrance of its products, which were much valued during a time when the consumption of sugar and spices was rising rapidly among European populations.

Coffee is another staple thing customarily associated with the area. In his *Dictionary*, Johnson indicates the Arabic origin of coffee and rightly so, as one the most popular types of coffee is called “Arabica” because it was first domesticated for commercial use in the southern part of Arabia the Happy (present-day Yemen). Given the Muslim prohibition of alcohol, coffee became particularly attractive to the Muslim world as “the wine of Islam,”²⁶ and spread through the ports of the Persian Gulf in Western Europe, where it became immensely popular. Collections of travels published during the time mention that coffee was “the product of Arabia only.”²⁷ Imported largely from Yemen, which was credited with producing the best coffee in the world, coffee was considered to have stimulating and therapeutic properties.²⁸ The former quality is famously described by Pope in *The Rape of the Lock*: “Coffee (which makes the politician wise), / And see thro’ all things with his half-shut Eyes) / Sent up in vapours to the Baron’s brain / New Stratagems, the radiant Lock to gain.”²⁹ According to Beawes, the product was brought to Mecca through the port of Jeddah, whose “[t]rade consists mainly of coffee brought here by the Arabians and bought by the



FIGURE 4.2 William Hogarth, *Taste in High Life* [graphic]. PRINT MADE BY ISAAC MILLS AFTER WILLIAM HOGARTH'S PAINTING, WITHOUT THE ARTIST'S PERMISSION, LONDON, 1798

Turks ... [and] by the Merchants of Mogul, Persia, and several places on the coast of Ehiopia.”³⁰ From here, coffee spread rapidly in England, France, and Italy, giving rise to the coffeehouse culture that is a hallmark of the eighteenth century. Coffee was also regularly paired in the visual culture of the time with expensive china (fig. 4.2), was employed as a mark of the culture of sociability (fig. 4.3), or was used for its oracular properties³¹ (fig. 4.4).

Arabian medicines were also much sought-after in the Western world. As indicated by Beawes, “from Arabia, Medicinal drugs, Dragon’s Blood, Manna, Myrrh, [and] Incense,”³² were brought to the British metropolis. *Pharmacopoeia Reformata* (1744) mentions gum Arabic, aloe, cassia, acacia, cardamom, saffron, myrrh, and spikenard, which were all used for their therapeutic properties.³³ To

25 Wiliam Beckford, *An Arabian Tale, from an Unpublished Manuscript: With Notes Critical and Explanatory* (London: Printed for J. Johnson, 1786), 165.

26 For the association between coffee and wine, see Ralph S. Hattox, *Coffee and Coffeehouses: The Origins of a Social Beverage in the Medieval Middle East* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1985), 18–19.

27 *A Collection of Voyages and Travels*, 1:440.

28 Coffee was customarily used as a mild painkiller during the eighteenth century. Poet Alexander Pope, for instance, used it as a palliative for his migraines.

29 Pope, *The Rape of the Lock*, 69.

30 Beawes, *Lex Mercatoria Rediviva*, 791.

31 Again, the custom of reading one’s fortune in coffee grounds is of Turkish provenance, not Arabic. Such mistaken attributions were pervasive during the eighteenth century.

32 Beawes, *Lex Mercatoria Rediviva*, 792.

33 M.M., *Pharmacopoeia Reformata: Or, An Essay for a Reformation of the London Pharmacopoeia, by a Set of Remarks on the Draught for a New One, and a Brief Account of the Proceedings of the Committee Appointed by the College of Physicians, to Thoroughly Reform Their*